✂️ Propagation: Reading

Horticulture 1 · Unit 7 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Propagation Methods, Vegetable Propagation worksheet, Propagation Journal

Name: _____

Making New Plants

Propagation is the making of new plants. Sexual propagation uses seeds, which form when pollen from one parent fertilizes the egg of another. The new plants vary, just as brothers and sisters differ. Asexual propagation uses parts of one plant, such as stems, leaves or roots. The new plant is a clone, an exact genetic copy of the parent.

Growers use asexual propagation when they want every plant to look the same. In a stem cutting, a 3-4 inch piece is cut just below a node, the lower leaves are removed, and the end is dipped in rooting hormone, a powder containing the plant hormone auxin. The cutting is stuck in moist mix and kept humid until roots form in two to four weeks.

Some plants grow from leaf cuttings. Succulent leaves are left to dry, or callus, for a few days and then laid on mix, where roots and a tiny plant form. Separation removes natural offsets, such as the 'chicks' around a hen-and-chicks plant. Division splits a clump, like an iris or hosta, into pieces that each have roots and shoots.

Many vegetables are propagated asexually: potatoes from seed pieces with eyes, garlic from cloves, strawberries from runners and sweet potatoes from slips. Rooting hormone and sharp tools require care: wear gloves, pour a little hormone into a cup rather than dipping into the jar, cut away from the body with an adult present, and wash hands afterward.

Check your reading

1. Compare sexual and asexual propagation.

2. List the steps for taking a stem cutting.

3. Why would a grower clone a plant instead of using seeds?